Kasturirangan, though he was not a patch on many others in terms of scientific or administrative skills.

The ISRO chairman, till then, was someone of tall stature, someone virtually everyone in the system looked up to. That ended with Rao. Since Kasturirangan, very ordinary people have sat on the big chair. I am not sure if ISRO would ever have as its chairman someone who will be in the league of the first three giants—Vikram Sarabhai, Satish Dhawan and U R Rao.

In 1993, as we were preparing for the PSLV launch, I made my calculations. I was now the project director of the second and fourth stages of PSLV, and also the project director of cryogenics. If U R Rao got an extension of service, which was likely, it would not be bad. If Muthunayagam becomes the chairman, which was unlikely, I would find it tough to get positions of importance; even my natural promotion as the LPSC director was doubtful.

I started working on an exit strategy. I had two immediate options. Go to the US, where I was sure to get a job in rocketry; get into some business where my engineering expertise can be put to use. A Kerala businessman named Kurien E Kalathil had approached me sometime earlier. A railway contractor then, Kurien had ambitious plans including a harbor project in Manila and shrimp farming in India. Kurien had been behind me for a sweat equity, and whenever I had tiffs with Muthunayagam I was prompted to say yes to the businessman. I kept it as a fallback option.

I used this contact, however, to get a job for my son Sankar, who had completed M. Com. Though I did not commit on a joint venture with Kurien, I helped him plan some ventures. For some of these, I offered advice and spoke to his prospective business partners abroad. For this Kurien had installed a telephone in my house in the name of my son. During the spy case, the investigators ‘unearthed’ the existence of this phone at my place, which had run ‘huge bills’ because of some international calls made.

These calls were primarily to Ron Zebel, an American expert in aqua culture who was employed by TIG with whom Kurien had struck a deal to start an aqua culture farm near Tiruchendur in south Tamil Nadu. Kurien